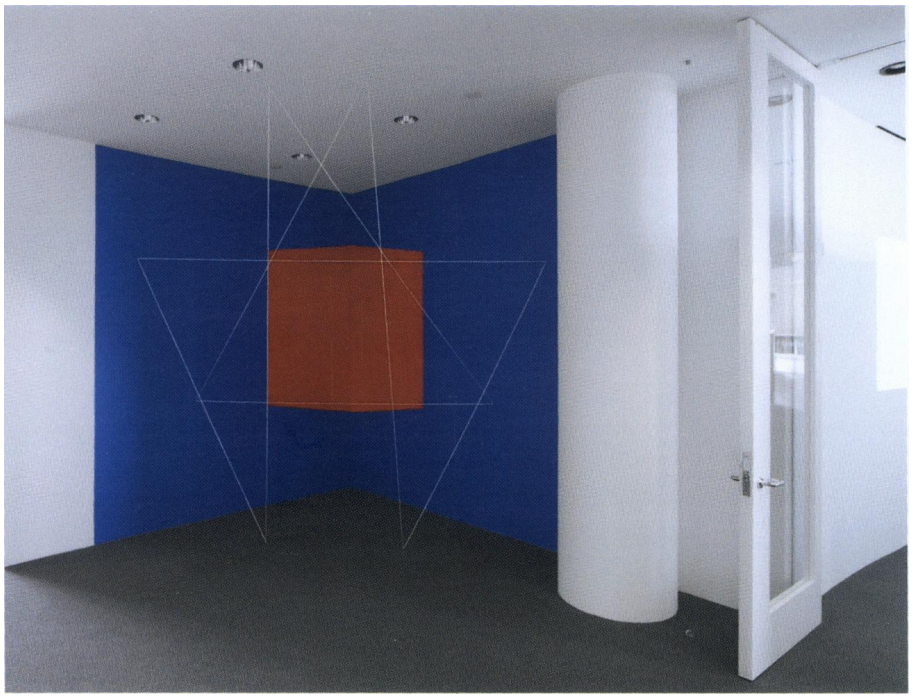

Tatlin Squared

When converging walls meet, the semienclosed wedge of space is turbulent. Why shouldn't it be? There are velocities involved. Add the definers of every indoor corner—the V above, the central seam, the inverted V below—which, if you think about it, offer a faint Vitruvian echo. The empty corner is full of content resisting anything that interferes with its self-definition.

To use the corner's assets against itself, you need to enter a perceptual conspiracy. The (indirect) light must be equalized on each wall, the seam absorbed into whiteness. These diminish the corner's powers.

To cancel the corner, or at least make it a cooperative partner, paint a square of pure color across the seam. Frame it with a string rebounding between walls, ceiling, floor. The red square on a blue ground, now framed in a nest of symmetrical triangles, retreats, advances, becomes solid and atmospheric, surface and depth. The spectator choreographs him- or herself to frame the perfect one-eyed view.

But this is only part of the "entertainment." The slightest move reforms the square (which is really a subtle hexagon). Lateral moves reveal superimpositions, parallaxes, a discourse on make-and-break gestalts. The perceptual motor of this conceit is the corner's efforts to retrieve itself and destroy the contemplative square.

Of course, this is just the artist's talk. The content of the work is probably elsewhere, since everything is completed by the receiver. The square has, as we know, a wonderful modernist pedigree. The corner, usually neglected, a more humble one. Vladimir Evgrafovich Tatlin opened up the corner in 1914–15 with the first corner-piece—which explains the title of this work.

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